OCTOBER 2026 EDITION · DATA VERIFIED OCTOBER 22, 2026

NEXT SOFTWARE ACADEMY

CAREER GUIDE & WORKBOOK

Action Workbook

Templates, exercises and 7-day / 30-day trackers.
Companion to the US Remote Job Playbook.

6
exercises

5
trackers

3
worksheets & templates

7 + 30
day plans

Print it or copy the tables into Google Sheets

No promises of employment or earnings. Verify every listing before you rely on it.

Action Workbook

How to Use This Workbook 2

Exercise 1: Your Skills & Proof Inventory 3

Exercise 2: Choose Your Lane 4

Exercise 3: Assessment & AI-Interview Prep Sheet 5

Exercise 4: STAR Story Bank 6

Exercise 5: Freelance Offer Builder 7

Exercise 6: Pricing Worksheet 8

Tracker 1: 7-Day Urgent Income 9

Tracker 2: 30-Day Stable Employment 10

Tracker 3: Application Pipeline 11

Tracker 4: Networking Log 12

Template: Coffee-Chat Notes 14

Tracker 5: Income & Payouts 15

Worksheet: Scam Check 16

Worksheet: Weekly Review 17

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook goes with the *US Remote Job Playbook*. Print it or copy the tables into Google Sheets. Each section has a chapter reference so you can find the full instructions.

Your setup checklist (Day 0)

- [ ] Filed for unemployment insurance (if laid off): date _____
- [ ] American Job Center appointment booked: date _____
- [ ] Tax savings bucket opened (25–30% of 1099 income)
- [ ] Verified PayPal in legal name · US bank account for Stripe/ACH
- [ ] Professional email · job-search folder created
- [ ] Weekly hours committed: Track 1 ____ hrs · Track 2 ____ hrs

Exercise 1: Your Skills & Proof Inventory

(Chapters 1, 7, 9.) List what you can **prove**. This inventory feeds every resume, profile, and AI interview.

Skill / domain knowledge	Where I used it (role, project)	Proof (number, result, link)	Platforms/jobs it fits

My top 3 sellable strengths:

1.
2.
3.

Exercise 2: Choose Your Lane

(Chapter 1.) Tick the statement that is true and write your first three platforms.

- [ ] I need money in 1–2 weeks → generalist AI training + studies + one freelance service
- [ ] I have deep professional expertise → expert AI training + expert networks
- [ ] I'm a US master's/PhD student or grad → Handshake AI Fellowship + Mercor/Alignerr
- [ ] I'm an undergrad/new grad → generalist AI training + Handshake jobs + startups + W-2 support roles
- [ ] I want a stable salaried remote job → targeted applications + networking (30-day plan)

Priority	Platform / employer	Link	Status label	Date applied
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

Exercise 3: Assessment & AI-Interview Prep Sheet

(Chapters 7 and 10.) Fill this in before every one-shot assessment or AI interview.

Item	Notes
Platform & role	
Format (assessment / AI video / human)	
One attempt only?	
Paid or unpaid?	
Date & 90-min block reserved	
Equipment test done (camera, mic, light, connection)	
Practice done (P14 / P16 / official practice)	

My 3 project stories (2 minutes each):

Project	My specific role	Method/tools	Result (number)

Exercise 4: STAR Story Bank

(Chapter 10, prompt P15.) Aim for 8 stories. Each should take 60–90 seconds to tell aloud.

Theme	Situation & Task	Action (what I did)	Result (number)	Questions it answers

Suggested themes: conflict · mistake · tight deadline · difficult customer · leading without authority · learning fast · improving a process · ambiguity.

Exercise 5: Freelance Offer Builder

(Chapter 8.)

My offer sentence: I help _____ (client) achieve _____ (outcome) by _____ (service), delivered in _____ (timeframe).

Demand check: job posts found in the last 7 days for this offer: _____

Portfolio sample	Problem it shows	Where hosted (link)	Labeled as sample?
1			
2			
3			

Exercise 6: Pricing Worksheet

(Chapter 8, prompt P13.) `Quote = (target take-home hourly × hours) ÷ (1 - platform fee)`

Line	Value
A. Target take-home hourly rate (before tax)	$
B. Estimated hours	
C. Platform fee (Upwork 0–15%, Fiverr 20%, Contra 0%)	%
D. Quote = (A × B) ÷ (1 − C)	$
E. Tax set-aside (25–30% of what you receive)	$
F. Scope: included	
G. Scope: not included / revisions	

Tracker 1: 7-Day Urgent Income

(Chapter 12, Track 1.)

Day	Focus	Actions	Done?	Notes / results
1	Generalist AI training + studies	DataAnnotation · Outlier · Prolific · UserTesting	[ ]	
2	Expert or W-2 route	Mercor ×2–3 · Alignerr · micro1 · GLG · Handshake AI · TELUS · W-2 CS roles	[ ]	
3	Package one skill	Offer sentence · 2 samples · P09 profile draft	[ ]	
4	Go live	Publish Upwork/Fiverr/Contra · 3–5 proposals	[ ]	
5	Warm network	T7 ×10 · Respondent · User Interviews	[ ]	
6	Assessments	Complete pending tests/interviews · 3–5 proposals	[ ]	
7	Review	Log all · P20 · plan next week	[ ]	

Daily minimums: [ ] 2 proposals · [ ] check AI dashboards ×2 · [ ] claim studies/tests · [ ] log everything

Tracker 2: 30-Day Stable Employment

(Chapter 12, Track 2.)

Week	Milestones	Target	Actual
1	Targets, resume, LinkedIn, 7-day networking plan	5 applications · 45 contacts · 25 messages	
2	Tailored applications + 3-touch sequence + chats	8–10 applications · 2–3 chats	
3	STAR bank, mock interviews, referrals	8–10 applications · ≥1 referral request	
4	Funnel review, follow-ups, negotiation prep	8–10 applications · P20 review	

Weekly scorecard

Metric	Target	Wk 1	Wk 2	Wk 3	Wk 4
Tailored applications	8–10				
Outreach messages	25				
Coffee chats	2–3				
Referral requests	1–2				
Recruiter screens	—				
Interviews	—				
Mock interviews	5				
Income received	—				

Tracker 3: Application Pipeline

(Chapters 9 and 11.) Stages: Applied → Screen → Interview → Final → Offer / Closed.

Date	Company / platform	Role / link	Fit (1–10)	Contact(s) messaged	Stage	Next step & date

Tracker 4: Networking Log

(Chapter 11.) Template codes: T1–T17.

Date	Name	Title / company	How found (alumni, posting, etc.)	Template	Reply?	Follow-up date	Outcome

Date	Name	Title / company	How found (alumni, posting, etc.)	Template	Reply?	Follow-up date	Outcome

Template: Coffee-Chat Notes

Name / title / company
Date / length
My 30-second intro (draft)
What great looks like on their team
Hardest skills to hire for
How hiring works there
People they suggested
Open roles mentioned
Thank-you sent (within 24 h)?
Referral appropriate? Next step

Tracker 5: Income & Payouts

(Chapter 5.) Track every payout. Set aside 25–30% of 1099 income for taxes.

Date	Platform / client	Work (task IDs, hours)	Gross $	Fee $	Net $	Tax set-aside $	Paid on time?

Worksheet: Scam Check

(Chapter 5.) Run this on any unexpected offer. **One “yes” = stop.**

Question	Yes	No
Do I have to pay anything (fees, equipment, “unlock” deposits)?	[ ]	[ ]
Did they contact me unsolicited via text/WhatsApp/Telegram/Signal?	[ ]	[ ]
Is the interview chat-only, with no named hiring manager?	[ ]	[ ]
Is the pay unusually high for simple work?	[ ]	[ ]
Is the email domain free or a look-alike?	[ ]	[ ]
Are they asking for my SSN/bank details before a written offer?	[ ]	[ ]
Did they send a check to buy equipment or forward money?	[ ]	[ ]
Is the job missing from the company’s official careers page?	[ ]	[ ]
Are they pressuring me to decide today?	[ ]	[ ]

Report: ReportFraud.ftc.gov · ic3.gov · the platform’s “Report” button.

Worksheet: Weekly Review

(Chapter 12, prompt P20.) Fill in every Friday.

Question	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Which channel produced replies?				
Which produced nothing (drop/fix)?				
Stalled items (7+ days) & follow-up sent?				
Interview feedback / lessons				
Income received vs. needed				
Top 3 actions for next week				
Energy level (1–5) & rest plan				